21LEM301T · INDIAN ART FORMS · CLA-II POSTER (CO4)

Kolam & Rangoli

Traditional Indian Floor Art: welcoming the divine, one pattern at a time

Every morning across India, doorsteps bloom with patterns drawn by hand on the ground. **Kolam** and **Rangoli** are ancient floor arts that decorate homes, welcome guests and gods, and carry centuries of faith, mathematics and community tradition.

Kolam

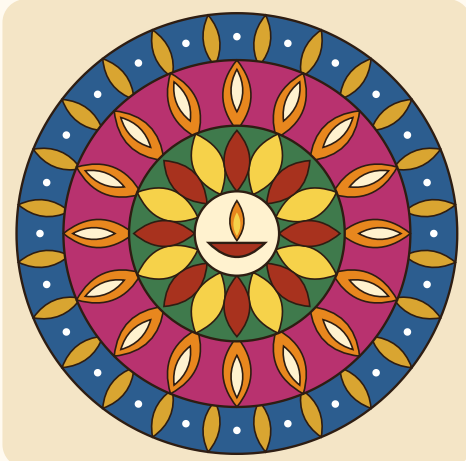
Tamil Nadu & South India · drawn daily at dawn



- Drawn with **white rice flour** (or rock powder) let fall between the thumb and fingers.
- Based on a **grid of dots (pulli)**; lines loop around the dots in one continuous path (*sikku kolam*).
- Mostly **white, symmetrical and geometric**; coloured on festivals.
- Made by women at sunrise after washing the threshold with water or cow-dung water.

Rangoli

Maharashtra, Gujarat & all of India · made on festivals



- Made with **coloured powders**, rice, lentils, sand, flower petals or chalk.
- Mostly **freehand**; designs include lotuses, peacocks, diyas, deities and mandalas.
- **Bright and multicoloured**, often filled edge to edge.
- Especially made for **Diwali**, weddings and other celebrations.

Kolam vs Rangoli at a Glance

Feature	Kolam	Rangoli
Region	Tamil Nadu, also Kerala, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh	Maharashtra, Gujarat, North & West India; known across India
Material	Rice flour or white stone powder	Coloured powders, flowers, rice, sand
Design base	Dot grid; continuous looping lines	Freehand outlines filled with colour
Colour	Mostly white	Many bright colours
When	Every day at dawn	Festivals and special occasions
Shared meaning	Welcomes Goddess Lakshmi, protects the home, expresses joy and hospitality	

Why We Draw Them

Cultural Meaning

- A sign of a **welcoming, happy home**; no kolam can signal mourning.
- Passed from **mother to daughter**, keeping skills and memory alive.
- Rice flour **feeds ants and birds**: daily charity to all living beings.
- Brings neighbours together, especially in festival contests.

Religious Meaning

- Invites **Goddess Lakshmi**, bringing prosperity and good fortune.
- Marks the threshold as **sacred** and keeps away evil and negativity.
- Drawn around altars, **tulsi** plants and puja spaces.
- Patterns like the lotus, sun and conch are holy symbols.

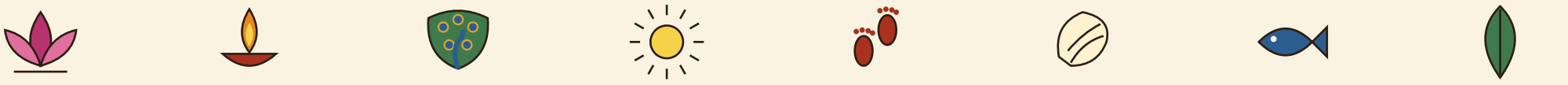
Festivals

- **Pongal / Sankranti:** giant coloured kolams with pots and sugarcane.
- **Diwali:** rangoli with diyas and Lakshmi's footprints.
- **Onam:** *pookalam* made of flower petals in Kerala.
- **Margazhi month:** daily kolam competitions in Tamil Nadu.

One Art, Many Names

Kolam Tamil Nadu	**Muggulu** Andhra & Telangana	**Rangavalli** Karnataka	**Pookalam** Kerala (flowers)	**Rangoli** Maharashtra & Gujarat
Alpana West Bengal	**Mandana** Rajasthan & MP	**Aripan** Bihar (Mithila)	**Chowk Purana** Uttar Pradesh	**Jhoti / Chita** Odisha

Common Motifs & Their Meaning



Lotus purity & Lakshmi · **Diya** light over darkness · **Peacock** beauty & grace · **Sun** energy & life · **Footprints** Lakshmi entering · **Conch** auspicious sound · **Fish** fertility & abundance · **Mango leaf** welcome & growth

Did you know? Kolam is a form of living mathematics. A *sikku* kolam is drawn as a single closed line that loops around every dot without lifting the hand, the same idea as an Eulerian path in graph theory. Computer scientists have even studied kolams to understand symmetry, fractals and picture languages.

Team: _____

Sources: course notes; IGNCA (ignca.gov.in); Ascher, M. "The Kolam Tradition", *American Scientist*, 2002